

The Sun is Rising Over India's Space Sector

2023 was a watershed year for India's space ambitions. With private players growing, and start-ups increasing, the sector is poised to become the world's envy by 2029

U **NDoubtedly among** India's many achievements in 2023, the success of the Chandrayaan-3 mission is a high point. India became the first country to land near the moon's South Pole, and the fourth country to soft land on the moon. This success put India's capabilities in space technology in the global spotlight.

Even as Chandrayaan-3 symbolises the new India raring to make its mark on the global space sector, there is a huge transformation taking place with space emerging as a sunrise sector in India. The Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro) continues to be a beacon of innovation, but the game changer in future will be through the participation of the country's private sector.

The past year has already seen a slew of announcements and initiatives by the government to strengthen the private space ecosystem. The creation of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACe) ignited the non-government entities (NGEs), creating a much-needed support system to participate in India's space economy. The much-appreciated Indian Space Policy 2023 laid the foundation for a structured and dynamic space sector, encouraging private sector participation in a range of activities from manufacturing rockets and satellites, launching them, operat-



BY PAWAN GOENKA

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ing earth stations, and disseminating satellite data to developing downstream space applications.

The year saw IN-SPACe implement multiple initiatives to encourage and handhold the private sector. The seed fund scheme for start-ups, pricing support policy, mentorship support, transfer of Isro technology to the private sector, design lab with simulation software and testing facilities for space objects, international outreach platforms for NGEs, and skill development are some of the key initiatives to encourage innovation and develop space capabilities of NGEs.

The result of these efforts is visible with the number of space start-ups now nearing 200 and investment in these start-ups increasing from \$6 million in 2019 to \$125 million in 2023. We are witnessing a growing interest from foreign players in Indian start-ups as well as legacy space companies. With the revised FDI policy that is around the corner, we should see higher investments in the space sector in the coming years.

The year also saw the unveiling of an ambitious decadal vision and strategy for the Indian space economy. We have set an aspiration for the Indian space economy to reach \$44 billion by 2033, from \$8.4 billion now and from a 2% share in the global space economy to 8% by 2033. NGEs are at the

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